

Structure the Partner Talk

“Turn and talk” works when everyone knows their job.

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Why it works

Unstructured partner talk often means one student talks and the other nods, and the student who nods is usually the English learner. Assigning roles and a time limit gives every student a turn, and turns are where language grows.

How to do it

- 1 Name Partner A and Partner B.**
Seat partners on purpose. Change them every few weeks.
- 2 Give each a job and a time.**
“A explains for thirty seconds. B repeats it back. Then switch.”
- 3 Listen in, then share a partner’s idea.**
“Tell us what your partner said.” It rewards listening.

What it looks like

Explain and repeat	A explains. B says, “So you are saying ____.”
Ask and answer	A asks the question on the board. B answers with the frame.
Agree and add	A gives an answer. B says, “I agree, and I would add ____.”
Coach	A solves aloud. B may only ask questions, not give answers.
Timing	Thirty to sixty seconds each. Use a visible timer.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Partners with a bilingual peer; repeats one key sentence.	Emerging Uses the posted frame for their turn.	Progressing Takes a full turn and paraphrases the partner.	Challenge Coaches a partner without giving the answer.
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Try it this week

Assign A and B partners in one class. Use “explain and repeat” once a day with a thirty-second timer.

What a visitor would see

Every student talking or listening in a timed turn, with roles on the board.

Teach the Conversation Moves

Academic talk has a script. Hand it out.

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Why it works

Students who are new to English, or new to school-style discussion, often stay silent because they do not know how to enter. Four conversation moves with ready-made starters give them a way in and make every discussion better.

How to do it

- 1 Post four moves with starters.**
Agree, add on, ask, and disagree politely.
- 2 Practice one move a day.**
"Today everyone must add on at least once."
- 3 Notice and name it.**
"Maria just built on Jalen's idea. That is what scholars do."

What it looks like

Agree	"I agree with ___ because ___."
Add on	"I would like to add to what ___ said."
Ask	"Can you explain what you mean by ___?" • "What is your evidence?"
Disagree politely	"I see it differently because ___."
Revoice	"So you are saying ___. Is that right?"

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Uses "I agree" and points to evidence.	Emerging Uses one starter from the wall.	Progressing Uses two different moves in one discussion.	Challenge Asks a question that pushes a classmate's thinking.
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Try it this week

Post the four moves. Choose one per day and require everyone to use it once.

What a visitor would see

Conversation starters on the wall and students using them with each other, not only with the teacher.

Share the Air

Who talked today? Who never does?

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Why it works

In most classrooms a handful of students do most of the talking, and English learners are rarely among them. That is not shyness; it is the speed of the room. A few changes to how you call on students give everyone time to prepare an answer.

How to do it

- 1 Wait five seconds, every time.**
Count silently. It feels long. It works.
- 2 Rehearse, then share.**
Partners talk first; then you call on anyone, because everyone has something to say.
- 3 Call on students warmly and at random.**
Name sticks or a random picker, with the right to say "Come back to me."

What it looks like

Preview the question	"In two minutes I will ask Luis about this. Luis, get ready."
Whip-around	Everyone says one word or phrase. No one is skipped; no one is put on the spot.
Write first	Thirty seconds of writing before anyone answers aloud.
Choice of answer	"Tell me the answer, or tell me what your partner said."
Track it	Keep a tally for one class period. The pattern will surprise you.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Answers with a word, a gesture, or a choice between two.	Emerging Answers after rehearsing with a partner.	Progressing Answers with a full sentence and a reason.	Challenge Invites a quieter classmate into the discussion.
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Try it this week

Tally who speaks in one class period. The next day, use five-second wait time and partner rehearsal, and tally again.

What a visitor would see

Long pauses after questions, and answers coming from every part of the room.

From Sentence to Paragraph

Claim, evidence, explain. Every subject.

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Why it works

Most written responses on state tests and in class ask for the same shape: make a point, prove it, and explain the proof. Students who learn that shape once can use it in every class. English learners need to see it, say it, and build it piece by piece.

How to do it

- 1 Teach the three parts with colors.**
Claim, evidence, explanation. Same colors in every class if your team agrees.
- 2 Build one together.**
Write a class paragraph on the board, one color at a time.
- 3 Give the frame, then fade it.**
Full frame this week, sentence starters next week, colors only after that.

In your subject

ELA	"The theme is _____. For example, the text says '_____.' This shows that _____."
Math	"The answer is _____. I know because _____. This makes sense because _____."
Science	"The data show _____. For instance, _____. This happened because _____."
Social studies	"_____ was a major cause of _____. According to the source, '_____.' This matters because _____."
Any class	The explanation is the part students skip. Require the word because or shows.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer

Completes a claim and copies one piece of evidence.

Emerging

Completes the full frame with a word bank.

Progressing

Writes all three parts with starters only.

Challenge

Adds a second piece of evidence and a counterpoint.

Try it this week

Write one claim–evidence–explanation paragraph with your class this week, in three colors.

What a visitor would see

Color-coded model paragraphs on display, and student writing with all three parts.

Grow the Sentence

Short, correct sentences are a stage, not a goal.

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Why it works

English learners often settle into short, safe sentences because those do not get marked wrong. Growth comes from joining and stretching them. Sentence combining is one of the few grammar practices with strong evidence that it improves writing.

How to do it

- 1 Start with two short sentences from your content.**
"The river rose. The levee held."
- 2 Join them three ways.**
and / but / so · because / although / when · which / who
- 3 Choose the best one for the meaning.**
Discuss why. That conversation is the grammar lesson.

In your subject

ELA	"Tomás was proud. He asked for help." → "Although Tomás was proud, he asked for help."
Math	"The angles are equal. The triangles are similar." → "Because the angles are equal, ..."
Science	"The ice melted. The water level stayed the same." → "When the ice melted, ..."
Social studies	"The law passed. Many people opposed it." → "The law passed, although ..."
Stretch it	Add when, where, or why to a short sentence: "Bats hunt." → "Bats hunt at night over the fields."

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Joins two sentences with and or but.	Emerging Joins with because or so.	Progressing Joins with although, when, or which.	Challenge Writes the same idea three ways and defends the best.
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Try it this week

Put two short sentences from your lesson on the board each day. Have students join them before class begins.

What a visitor would see

A daily two-sentence warm-up on the board, and longer sentences appearing in student writing.

Feedback That Sticks

Mark less. Teach more.

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Why it works

A paper covered in corrections teaches a student that English is impossible. Feedback works when it names one pattern, shows it once, and makes the student do the fixing. One target a week adds up to many by May.

How to do it

- 1 Choose one language target for the class or the student.**
Past-tense -ed, capital letters, subject-verb agreement.
- 2 Mark the first example, then only put a dot in the margin.**
The student finds and fixes the rest.
- 3 Have students keep a personal checklist.**
Three targets at most. Check them before turning work in.

What it looks like

Say what is right first	"Your claim is clear and your evidence fits."
Name one target	"This week, check every verb that happened in the past for -ed."
Margin dots	A dot means: there is one in this line. Find it.
Two-minute fix	Give class time to correct. Feedback without time to act is decoration.
Ignore the rest	For now. You will get to it. Accuracy grows in layers.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Target: capital letter and period.	Emerging Target: subject and verb in every sentence.	Progressing Target: verb tense or agreement.	Challenge Target: word choice and sentence variety.
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Try it this week

On the next piece of writing, give content feedback plus one language target. Use margin dots and two minutes of fix time.

What a visitor would see

Student papers with a few dots in the margin, and students correcting their own work.

ELPA21 Season: What It Measures

Four domains, and every class teaches them.

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Why it works

Each year our English learners take the ELPA21, the state's English proficiency assessment. It measures listening, speaking, reading, and writing, and the results decide services and exit from the program. It is not a test of the EL class alone. Students build these skills in every room.

How to do it

- 1 Know the four domains.**
Listening, speaking, reading, writing. Speaking answers are recorded on a computer.
- 2 Give daily practice in the two we skip.**
Most classes practice reading and writing. Speaking and listening need deliberate time.
- 3 Normalize the format.**
Speaking aloud to a screen feels strange. Let students try it before it counts.

What it looks like

Listening	Give directions once, aloud, and have students repeat them to a partner.
Speaking	One sixty-second spoken explanation a week, to a partner or recorded on a Chromebook.
Reading	Short informational texts with questions that ask for evidence.
Writing	Short constructed responses: a claim and a reason, typed.
On test days	Students may miss your class. Please let them make up work without penalty.

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer Practices following one-step spoken directions.	Emerging Records a two-sentence answer and listens to it.	Progressing Records a thirty-second explanation with a reason.	Challenge Records, listens, and re-records to improve.
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Try it this week

Have students record one short spoken explanation on their Chromebooks this week, about your content.

What a visitor would see

Students speaking into devices without embarrassment, because they have done it before.

The Language of Test Questions

They often know the content. The question trips them.

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Why it works

State test questions use a small set of words that carry a great deal of meaning and are almost never taught. A student who understands photosynthesis can still miss the item because of the word *except*. These words can be taught in minutes.

How to do it

- 1 Collect the question words from your released items.**
Most subjects use fewer than twenty.
- 2 Teach one a day with an example.**
Post it, translate it, and use it in your own questions.
- 3 Have students rewrite the question in their own words.**
If they can restate it, they can answer it.

In your subject

ELA	best supports • most likely • central idea • as used in paragraph 3 • primarily
Math	at least • no more than • in terms of • approximately • which expression represents
Science	best explains • most likely cause • which model • based on the data
Social studies	primary source • according to the excerpt • which statement best describes • main purpose
All tests	except • not • select two • Part A and Part B

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer

Learns the words with translations and symbols.

Emerging

Matches each question word to what it asks for.

Progressing

Restates a test question in plain English.

Challenge

Writes a test-style question using two of the words.

Try it this week

Pull five question words from a released test in your subject. Teach one a day and use it in your own quizzes.

What a visitor would see

A short list of test question words on the wall, with translations, and quizzes that use them.

Stamina and Calm

Long tests are a physical event.

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Why it works

Reading in a second language is tiring in a way that is hard to imagine until you have done it. A student who is strong for forty minutes may guess for the last ninety. Stamina and calm can both be trained, starting now, in small steps.

How to do it

- 1 Lengthen independent work gradually.**
Add five minutes a week to sustained silent work.
- 2 Teach a break routine.**
Eyes closed, three slow breaths, stretch the hands, begin again.
- 3 Teach a plan for being stuck.**
Mark it, move on, come back. Never leave a blank.

What it looks like

Build up	Twenty minutes this week, twenty-five next week. Post the class record.
Practice the break	Do it together in the middle of a long task so it is automatic in May.
Talk about nerves	Say aloud that the test does not measure intelligence, and that reading in a second language is hard work.
Sleep and breakfast	A short note home, in the family's language, the week before.
Directions vocabulary	select, drag, highlight, review, submit, flag for later

Same move, four lanes

Newcomer

Learns the directions vocabulary and the break routine.

Emerging

Works ten minutes longer than in August.

Progressing

Uses mark, move on, come back without reminders.

Challenge

Helps the class track and beat its stamina record.

Try it this week

Time one stretch of sustained independent work this week. Add five minutes next week. Practice the break routine once.

What a visitor would see

A class working silently for a posted number of minutes, and a shared, practiced way to reset.